

Fire making helped humans cook, keep warm, and protect themselves.

2.5 mya

Getting cleverer

Stone tools helped early humans eat a wider variety of food. The more skilled they became at making tools, the better they were at surviving. Toolmaking required thinking, so our smartest relatives became the most successful at staying alive.

1.7 mya

Hunting and language

As our relatives became more intelligent, they made tools to hunt large animals. It was dangerous work, so humans needed to plan and hunt as a team. This required clever thinking and a sharing of ideas, which led us to develop language.

Early people hunted woolly mammoths with spears.

100 kya



Eventually, people lived in all parts of the world except Antarctica.

Humans on the move

The first humans that were like us evolved in Africa. When some of them left, they gradually crossed into new continents. Some areas had cold climates and strange animals, such as the woolly mammoth.

12 kya

Early settlers began farming crops and taming animals for milk and wool.



Settling down

Humans had to move around regularly to hunt animals. Then some people began farming in one place. They built houses and farms, eventually forming towns and cities, trading with each other, and slowly building our modern world.

